

Stroke Care Protocol

Code Stroke, tPA Administration, and Stroke Center Standards

Regulation: 42 CFR §482.21 | STK Core Measures | TJC Primary Stroke Center

POLICY OVERVIEW

Stroke is a time-critical neurological emergency where outcomes are directly tied to speed of recognition and treatment. Hospitals must have systems to rapidly identify and treat stroke patients, with primary stroke center certification requiring compliance with evidence-based care bundles.

KEY REQUIREMENTS

1 Code Stroke Activation

A single activation number or system must initiate a coordinated Code Stroke response. The response team must include: emergency physician, neurologist (or teleneurology), CT technician, pharmacist, and nursing. Target door-to-CT time is under 25 minutes.

2 tPA/Thrombolytic Administration

Eligible ischemic stroke patients must receive IV alteplase within 60 minutes of arrival (door-to-needle time). Strict inclusion/exclusion criteria must be followed. A checklist-based workflow reduces errors. Endovascular treatment (thrombectomy) must be considered for large vessel occlusion.

3 Stroke Unit Care

Admitted stroke patients must be cared for in a dedicated stroke unit or by a stroke-trained team with access to: continuous cardiac monitoring, dysphagia screening before oral intake, early PT/OT/speech therapy, and VTE prophylaxis.

4 Secondary Prevention

Before discharge, ischemic stroke patients must receive: antiplatelet therapy (or anticoagulation for AF-related stroke), statin therapy, antihypertensive therapy, and smoking cessation counseling. Atrial fibrillation screening must be performed.

5 Stroke Education and Rehabilitation

Patients and families must receive education on stroke recognition (FAST), risk factor modification, medication adherence, and warning signs of recurrent stroke. Rehabilitation needs must be assessed and appropriate post-acute care arranged.

COMPLIANCE NOTES

Joint Commission Primary Stroke Center (PSC) or Comprehensive Stroke Center (CSC) certification requires ongoing compliance with STK core measures. Stroke data must be submitted to a registry (Get With The Guidelines) and reviewed by the stroke committee.

COMMON SURVEY CITATIONS

Measured under CMS STK Core Measures, and required for TJC Primary Stroke Center Certification.